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# Fake KYC Vectors

An intermediate-level guide to spotting fake banking and telecom KYC messages, impersonation calls, malicious links, and identity-theft attempts.

| LEVEL | CURRICULUM | FOCUS |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Intermediate | 5 lessons | Banking + Telecom KYC |

## What this guide teaches

- How legitimate KYC and periodic KYC updates normally work.
- How fake SMS, WhatsApp messages, emails, calls, and websites imitate banks and telecom providers.
- How to inspect links, sender details, requests for documents, and suspicious apps.
- How to verify a request through an official channel without using contact details supplied by the suspicious message.
- How to respond if personal information, documents, OTPs, or money have already been exposed.

**CORE RULE**

Never complete KYC through an unsolicited link or a caller's instructions. Pause, independently contact the bank or telecom provider using its official app, website, branch, or published customer-care channel.

## Important context

KYC (Know Your Customer) is a genuine identity-verification process used by regulated entities. The existence of real KYC requirements is what makes fake KYC messages believable. A message mentioning KYC is not automatically fraudulent—but a request for urgent action through an unknown link, number, or app must be independently verified.

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# Five-lesson learning path

| Lesson | Topic |
|---|---|
| 1 | KYC fundamentals: what is real and what is not |
| 2 | Fake KYC vectors: SMS, calls, WhatsApp, email, and websites |
| 3 | Link, sender, and app inspection |
| 4 | Identity theft, document misuse, and safe verification |
| 5 | Incident response, reporting, and recovery steps |
| Quick reference | Verification checklist, warning signs, quiz, glossary, sources |

**A SIMPLE DECISION RULE**

Do not trust the message's phone number, link, logo, sender name, or urgency claim as proof. Verify the request independently through a channel you locate yourself.

LESSON 1 | KYC FUNDAMENTALS

# What is real KYC?

KYC means “Know Your Customer”. Banks and other regulated entities use it to establish and periodically update customer identity information. Depending on the institution and service, the process may involve identity and address details, documents, or an approved digital verification method.

## 1.1 Why institutions request KYC

KYC helps a regulated entity understand who it is providing services to and helps reduce misuse of financial services. KYC may be required when an account or customer relationship begins, when certain services are used, or when periodic updating is due. The exact requirement and accepted method depend on the institution and applicable rules.

## 1.2 Periodic KYC updates are real—but verify the route

RBI guidance says regulated entities should give advance intimation when periodic KYC updating is due and send reminders if it remains pending. RBI also specifically warns customers to exercise utmost caution with SMS or email links that claim to complete KYC updating because such links may be suspicious or fraudulent. A genuine KYC requirement does not make every link or caller genuine.

**IMPORTANT DISTINCTION**

A real KYC requirement may exist. That does not mean the SMS, caller, WhatsApp account, website, or app contacting you is authorised. Verify directly with your bank or regulated entity.

## 1.3 What legitimate communication should lead you to do

- Open the bank’s official app yourself, or type its known official website address into your browser.
- Call the number published on the official website, bank statement, card, or app—not a number in the suspicious message.
- Ask whether your KYC is due and which official methods are available.
- If visiting a branch is appropriate, use a branch address obtained independently.
- Keep the acknowledgement or reference provided by the institution after a genuine update.

## 1.4 What should make you pause

- A threat that your account or SIM will be blocked within minutes unless you click a link.
- A demand to share OTP, PIN, password, CVV, or account login details.
- A request to install an APK, remote-access app, or screen-sharing tool.
- A demand to send identity documents to a personal number or unknown email address.
- A caller who refuses to let you verify through the official bank or telecom provider.

**REMEMBER**

KYC is a process—not a magic word that makes an unknown link trustworthy. Confirm the requirement independently before submitting anything.

# How scammers approach you

A “vector” is the route or method used to reach a target. Fake KYC campaigns can arrive through multiple channels and often combine impersonation, urgency, a malicious link, and a request for sensitive information.

## 2.1 SMS and messaging-app vectors

**Typical message:** “Your bank account will be suspended today. Complete re-KYC immediately: [link].” The message may use a bank name, official-looking language, or a sender label designed to appear familiar.

**What the scammer wants:** You to tap the link, enter login details, share OTPs, upload identity documents, or install an app.

**Safer response:** Do not tap the link. Open the official app or contact the institution independently to check whether KYC is actually due.

## 2.2 Voice-call impersonation (vishing)

A caller may claim to be from a bank, telecom provider, regulator, or government office. They may say your account, SIM, or mobile number will be blocked unless you act immediately. RBI warns that fraudsters use calls and messages to impersonate banks and telecom providers, including under the pretext of KYC updates or unblocking accounts/SIM cards.

**Safer response:** End the call politely. Find the official customer-care contact yourself and verify the claim. Never share PINs, passwords, OTPs, or card security details.

## 2.3 Fake telecom disconnection threats

TRAI has warned that it does not initiate customer communication threatening mobile-number disconnection through messages or otherwise, and has not authorised third-party agencies to contact customers for this purpose. A message claiming “TRAI will disconnect your number” should be treated as a potential fraud attempt. For a genuine service issue, independently contact your telecom operator.

## 2.4 Fake websites and lookalike portals

A scam site may copy a bank or telecom logo, colours, login screen, and wording. The domain name may contain extra words, misspellings, unusual endings, or characters that look similar to the real brand. A padlock/HTTPS connection only means the connection is encrypted; it does not prove that the website belongs to the organisation it claims to represent.

## 2.5 Malicious apps and remote access

A message or caller may ask you to install an APK or an app that enables screen sharing or remote control. Such access can expose notifications, messages, and sensitive information, or let a fraudster guide you into making a payment. Do not install apps from unknown links or grant permissions at a stranger’s request.

**COMMON PRESSURE SCRIPT**

“Your account will be blocked in 30 minutes. I am helping you avoid the block. Do not disconnect; click this link and read me the OTP.” This combination of urgency, authority, secrecy, and credential collection is a major warning sign.

LESSON 3 | INSPECTION SKILLS

# Check the link, sender, and app

A professional-looking message can still be fake. Use the following checks as clues—not as a guarantee. If a request involves KYC, verify it independently even when the message looks convincing.

## 3.1 Inspect the full domain name

• Read the actual domain from right to left, focusing on the registered domain—not just the words at the beginning of the URL.

• Watch for misspellings, extra words, hyphens, unusual subdomains, and unrelated domain endings.

• A URL such as **bankname.verify-example.com** belongs to **verify-example.com**, not necessarily to the bank named in the subdomain.

• Do not assume HTTPS, a padlock, a logo, or a professional design proves legitimacy.

• Avoid opening shortened or unexpected links. Navigate to the organisation's known official site yourself.

## 3.2 Inspect the sender and message

• Check whether the message was expected and whether the sender can be independently verified.

• Do not treat a display name, profile photo, SMS header, or caller ID as proof of identity.

• Look for unusual grammar, generic greetings, strange formatting, and requests that do not match normal account activity.

• Be cautious of messages that create a deadline, threaten closure, or promise instant restoration.

• Never reply with identity documents, account details, OTPs, PINs, or passwords.

## 3.3 Inspect an app request

• Use the official app store listing reached through the provider's official website where possible.

• Check the app publisher/developer name and whether the app is the provider's genuine app.

• Do not install an APK file received over SMS, WhatsApp, Telegram, or a phone call.

• Do not grant Accessibility, SMS, notification, screen-sharing, or device-administrator permissions to an unknown app.

• If you installed a suspicious app, stop using it, disconnect it from sensitive accounts, and seek trusted technical support to remove it safely.

## 3.4 A practical example

**Message:** "Dear customer, your mobile number will be permanently disconnected tonight due to incomplete KYC. Download this update app now."

**Warning signs:** A severe deadline, threat of disconnection, unknown app download, and an unsolicited request. If the message claims to be from TRAI, remember that TRAI says it does not initiate such mobile-disconnection threats to customers.

**Safe action:** Do not install the app. Contact your own telecom operator through its official app or published customer-care channel. You can report suspected fraudulent communication through DoT's Chakshu facility on Sanchar Saathi.

> **DO NOT TEST A LINK BY ENTERING FAKE DETAILS**
>
> Even a test submission can expose device or browser information and may lead you deeper into a malicious flow. Do not interact with a suspicious KYC portal. Verify the claim through an official channel instead.

LESSON 4 | IDENTITY PROTECTION

# Protect your identity and documents

KYC-related information can be valuable to criminals. A copied identity document, personal detail, or account credential may be misused for impersonation or social engineering. Share only what is genuinely required, through a verified process.

## 4.1 Sensitive information to protect

• **Banking credentials:** login ID, password, transaction password, PIN, OTP, card number, CVV, and expiry details.

• **Identity documents:** Aadhaar, PAN, passport, voter ID, driving licence, and copies of supporting documents.

• **Account information:** account number, customer ID, registered mobile number, email, and statements.

• **Device access:** screen-sharing sessions, remote-control permissions, SMS access, and notification access.

## 4.2 Safer document-sharing practices

• First confirm that the institution actually requires the document and that the channel is official.

• Use the provider's official app, website, branch, or verified process—not a link sent by an unknown person.

• Share only the documents and fields required for the stated purpose.

• Where the institution accepts it, consider using a purpose-specific, appropriately masked copy and a clear watermark such as "For KYC with [institution] only – [date]". Do not alter a document if the institution requires an unmodified official document.

• Do not send identity documents to personal WhatsApp numbers or unknown email addresses.

• Keep records of where and when you submitted documents.

## 4.3 If someone asks for OTP or PIN

Do not disclose it. A legitimate support representative should not ask you to reveal your OTP, UPI PIN, card PIN, or password. If you receive an OTP you did not request, do not share it; check your accounts through official channels and contact the provider if you suspect an attempt to access your account.

## 4.4 If you already clicked a link

• If you only opened the page but entered nothing and installed nothing, close it. Do not continue or download files.

• If you entered a password, change it using the official website/app from a trusted device and review account activity.

• If you shared banking credentials or OTPs, contact your bank immediately using an official channel.

• If you installed an unknown app or gave remote access, stop interacting with the caller, disconnect the session, and get trusted help securing the device.

• If money was lost, report immediately through 1930 and cybercrime.gov.in.

LESSON 5 | RESPONSE & REPORTING

# What to do if you receive or fall for a fake KYC attempt

Choose the response that matches what happened. Do not delay reporting a financial loss while trying to negotiate with the suspected scammer.

## 5.1 You received a suspicious message or call, but did not interact

• Do not click, reply, call back, scan a QR code, or install an app.

• Save the message, sender information, date/time, and screenshot as evidence.

• For suspected fraudulent communications, use the Chakshu facility on the Department of Telecommunications' Sanchar Saathi platform: https://sancharsaathi.gov.in/sfc/.

• For unwanted commercial spam, use your telecom provider's complaint/reporting process or TRAI's prescribed channels such as 1909.

## 5.2 You shared KYC documents or personal information

• Contact the relevant bank or service provider using official contact details and explain exactly what was shared.

• Ask the institution what protective steps are available for the affected account or service.

• Watch for unexpected account activity, new service notifications, password-reset messages, or unfamiliar verification requests.

• Keep copies of messages and records of the incident. Report suspected cybercrime through the official portal if appropriate.

## 5.3 You shared an OTP, PIN, password, or banking details

• Contact your bank immediately through the official app, website, branch, or published number.

• Ask the bank to secure the account, block affected payment instruments or channels where appropriate, and register a complaint.

• Change compromised passwords from a trusted device and review recent account activity.

• If money has been lost or a financial cyber fraud has occurred, call 1930 immediately and file a complaint at https://cybercrime.gov.in/.

## 5.4 You installed an unknown app or gave remote access

• End the remote session and stop following the caller's instructions.

• Use a trusted device to contact your bank and secure affected accounts.

• Get reliable technical help to remove the app and check for suspicious device permissions or profiles.

• Change affected passwords and review account activity after the device is secured.

## 5.5 Preserve evidence

• Keep the original SMS/email/chat, sender ID or number, URL, call time, and screenshots.

• Record the name of the bank or telecom provider involved and the official complaint/reference numbers.

• For financial loss, keep transaction ID/UTR, amount, date/time, and recipient details.

• Do not publish personal documents, OTPs, account numbers, or sensitive screenshots on social media.

**FINANCIAL CYBER FRAUD IN INDIA**

Call **1930** promptly and report at **https://cybercrime.gov.in/**. Contact your bank immediately as well. Reporting quickly may help the response, but it does not guarantee recovery of funds.

QUICK REFERENCE

# Fake KYC verification checklist

Before acting on any KYC message, check every item below.

| Check | Safe practice |
|---|---|
| Was I expecting a KYC update? | If not, treat the message cautiously and verify independently. |
| Can I confirm the request through the official app/website/branch? | Use a channel you locate yourself—not the link or number in the message. |
| Is the message threatening immediate closure or disconnection? | Pause. Urgency and threats are common pressure tactics. |
| Is it asking for OTP, PIN, password, CVV, or login details? | Do not share them. Stop and contact the institution. |
| Is it asking me to install an APK or remote-access app? | Do not install it or grant permissions. |
| Is the domain genuinely controlled by the organisation? | Do not rely on logos, HTTPS, or a familiar-looking subdomain. |
| Have I saved evidence if it looks suspicious? | Keep sender details, link, message, date/time, and screenshots. |

## Warning signs at a glance

• “Your account/SIM will be blocked in 30 minutes.”

• “Click this link to complete KYC immediately.”

• “Install this APK to keep your number active.”

• “Tell me the OTP so I can verify your identity.”

• “Share your screen; I will complete the update for you.”

• “Send your Aadhaar/PAN to this personal WhatsApp number.”

• “Do not contact the bank; I am handling your KYC.”

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

# Intermediate quiz

Choose the safest response. Answers follow the questions.

## 1. You receive an SMS saying your bank account will be frozen today unless you update KYC through a link.

A. Click immediately

B. Open your bank's official app or contact the bank independently

C. Reply with your account number

## 2. A caller says they are from TRAI and your mobile number will be disconnected unless you share details.

A. Share details

B. Follow their link

C. End the call and verify with your telecom operator; TRAI says it does not initiate such disconnection threats

## 3. A KYC website has a padlock and the bank logo. Is that proof it is genuine?

A. Yes

B. No; verify the domain and use the official channel

C. Yes, if the page looks professional

## 4. A person asks you to install an APK for KYC and grant SMS access.

A. Install it

B. Do not install it; verify through the official provider

C. Install it only after a phone call

## 5. You shared an OTP and then noticed an unexpected banking alert.

A. Wait and see

B. Contact the bank immediately and secure the account

C. Send another OTP to the caller

## 6. You received a suspicious KYC message but did not click it. Which reporting route can be used for suspected telecom fraud communication?

A. DoT Chakshu on Sanchar Saathi

B. Send your PIN to the sender

C. Install the app mentioned

## 7. Money was lost after a fake KYC call. What should you do?

A. Pay a recovery agent

B. Call 1930, report at cybercrime.gov.in, and contact your bank immediately

C. Delete all messages

## Answer key

**1. B** — Independently verify the KYC requirement. Do not use an unsolicited link.

**2. C** — TRAI has stated it does not initiate mobile-disconnection threats to customers through messages or otherwise.

**3. B** — HTTPS and logos do not prove ownership or legitimacy.

**4. B** — Do not install unknown apps or grant sensitive permissions.

**5. B** — Contact the bank immediately and secure affected access.

**6. A** — Chakshu is the DoT facility for reporting suspected fraudulent communications.

**7. B** — Report promptly through 1930 and the official portal, and inform the bank.

GLOSSARY & OFFICIAL SOURCES

# Key terms

| | |
|---|---|
| **KYC** | Know Your Customer: identity verification and periodic updating carried out by regulated entities. |
| **Periodic KYC** | A scheduled update of customer information when required by the regulated entity and applicable rules. |
| **Phishing** | A deceptive message or website designed to trick a person into revealing information or taking an unsafe action. |
| **Vishing** | A fraud attempt conducted through voice calls, often using impersonation. |
| **Smishing** | A phishing attempt delivered through SMS or text messages. |
| **Lookalike domain** | A domain designed to resemble a legitimate organisation's web address. |
| **Remote-access app** | Software that can let another person view or control a device, depending on permissions. |
| **Chakshu** | A facility on DoT's Sanchar Saathi platform to report suspected fraudulent communication. |

## Official references

Use these primary sources to confirm current instructions. This guide was prepared on 14 November 2026; websites and procedures may change.

**RBI – Cautions against frauds in the name of KYC updation (2 Feb 2024)**
https://www.rbi.org.in/Scripts/BS_PressReleaseDisplay.aspx?prid=57244
Explains unsolicited calls/SMS/emails, urgency threats, unauthorised apps, and do's and don'ts.

**RBI – KYC FAQs (updated 9 Jun 2025)**
https://www.rbi.org.in/commonman/Upload/English/FAQs/PDFs/KYC09062025.pdf
Explains periodic KYC updates and cautions against suspicious links in SMS/email.

**RBI – Consumer Awareness: Cyber Threats and Frauds (28 Jan 2022)**
https://www.rbi.org.in/scripts/FS_PressRelease.aspx?prid=53185
Covers vishing, fake KYC calls, malicious apps, suspicious URLs, and QR/MPIN cautions.

**TRAI – Beware of fraudulent calls impersonating TRAI (21 Aug 2024)**
https://trai.gov.in/sites/default/files/2024-10/PR_No.55of2024.pdf
Clarifies that TRAI does not initiate customer communication threatening mobile-number disconnection.

**DoT Sanchar Saathi – Chakshu**
https://sancharsaathi.gov.in/sfc/
Facility to report suspected fraudulent communication.

**National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal**
https://cybercrime.gov.in/
Official portal for reporting cybercrime; financial cyber fraud helpline 1930.

**I4C Portal – Report Suspect**
https://cybercrime.gov.in/Webform/cyber_suspect.aspx
Allows reporting suspicious URLs, phone numbers, messaging handles, email IDs, SMS headers/numbers, and social-media URLs.

**INFRAUD DISCLAIMER**

This guide is educational. An INFRAUD scan or risk result is not an official bank, RBI, TRAI, or telecom-provider verification. It cannot prove who sent a message, confirm ownership of a phone number, or guarantee that a link is safe. Always verify through official channels.

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**Check Before You Trust.**